

BIG BYTE

Flash is bigger, faster, and cheaper than ever before. Ride the wave at its cusp—you've got 34 of them to choose from

*Nothing is permanent
but change.*

—Heraclitus

Michael Browne

While nobody will dispute the accuracy of the above statement it's equally true that storage hasn't followed this trend in recent years. Sure we've had bigger, faster hard drives, and even greater capacities on optical media, as parallel recording gave way to perpendicular recording and CDs gave way to DVDs and dual-layer DVDs.

Flash memory has always been considered a dark horse. It promised to be a great ride for pioneers of the technology, but the risks were equally big. Every technology needs a catalyst to speed up its development into a mature product. Flash has two things working in its favour now—the need for a dependable portable medium to carry data, and the fact that magnetic recording (HDDs) have come close to their limits both as far as speed and capacity go.

Today, examples of Flash storage can be seen from the solid-state hard drives that have begun to appear in laptops to the humble subjects in this test. Greater size and speed in addition to the ever diminishing price makes flash drives perhaps one of the best buys this year. We were shocked when the prices of 4 GB flash memory plummeted to around Rs 1,500—just a year ago the prices were more than double that. Higher capacities (16 GB and above) are still pricey enough to intimidate all but the most persistent buyer, but that's sure to change, just wait and watch. Perhaps more surprising was the

increments in speed of read / write operations—sadly, we don't get to take coffee breaks between tests any more.

We scoured the market and chose 34 drives from amongst the masses—each contender was chosen on the basis of it offering something unique—whether in terms of value, or performance, or appeal.

SKINNY BYTES—1 GB Features

Out of the five drives we tested in this section, we really liked the rugged build of the Corsair Voyager 1 GB. Built with a high-quality rubber / silicone compound, the Voyager easily resists damage when dropped. Despite the soft body, it doesn't feel flimsy to hold or use. Transcend's JetFlash 168 was another beauty. One side of the surface has a silver metallic sticker with beautiful embossing. The quality of the plastic used is good. Other than the Moser Baer 1 GB—which had a swivel type design and a quality metal outer sheath—the other two drives were pretty ordinary.

Corsair had some sort of a security application installed on each of their Voyager series drives—but this didn't prove to be really secure—a format removed the application entirely! Not good for someone who wants to protect data.

Performance

The Moser Baer 1 GB proved to be speedy overall. Although the Transcend JetFlash 168 shocked us in the 100 MB assorted file test with 4.11 MBps—an unheard of speed for a random write operation—so much so that we ran the benchmark again to be sure. In fact these two fought it out fiercely, but Moser Baer's offering won the race in the end.

BEST BUY
diGit
JANUARY 2008



MoserBaer 1 GB
Small n fast!

How We Tested

We used Windows XP Professional with SP2. All testing was done on a secondary partition to avoid hard drive bottlenecks. We turned off functions like System Restore, and also kept a permanent swap file on a separate 1.5 GB primary partition.

Test Machine Specification

Processor	Pentium 4 520 (3.2 GHz)
Motherboard	Gigabyte P965 DQ6
RAM	Kingston DDR2 800 MHz 512x2
HDD	Hitachi T7K 250GB SATA 2
Graphics Card	NVIDIA GeForce 7600GS

Features:

- ☑ Points were awarded for security features (encryption, password locking etc), we even tested the security feature (if present) to ascertain its strength
- ☑ Software features include any firmware on the drive and

the bundle. We awarded extra points for backup and recovery and sync suites bundled

- ☑ An LED is a must to know when a read/write operation is being performed
- ☑ Accessories being the life breath of any personal device were awarded points for simply being part of the bundle. We looked for extras like belt chains and hooks, lanyard rings, and neck straps
- ☑ Other features included something noteworthy in a particular product that made it unique

Performance:

- ☑ HD Tach tests and reports on five parameters. We've listed all five but only taken three (the read/write scores) into contention for our calculations.
- ☑ SiSoft Sandra 2007 tests the read / write performance of a flash drive. We gave more bias to the write scores.
- ☑ Our file transfer tests consisted of two parts—one was a 100 MB file transfer test, the other was a maximum size transfer test. We ran both sequential (one large file) and random (lots of different files of varying size) tests.